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PALM SPRINGS has adorned its downtown with banners expressing affection for Canadians, who have long pumped millions of dollars into the economy each winter as they trade their heavy coats for resortwear.

Canadian snowbirds, stung by Trump, flock from Palm Springs

The city braces for an economic hit as homes are sold and vacations canceled.

BY HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS

PALM SPRINGS — Christopher Climie, who recently moved to Palm Springs, was supposed to be hosting visitors from his native Canada this week. Ten friends — all gay men, like Climie — had planned to fly in from Toronto. They were going to



CHRISTOPHER CLIMIE says 10 friends from Toronto canceled a visit because of President Trump.

trade the cold and rain for a hot desert weekend at the Coachella Valley Music and Arts Festival, where their beloved Lady Gaga is set to perform. But because of tensions between Canada and President Trump, they canceled their plans. “They were like, ‘No, Gaga is not worth it,’” said Climie, 39. “For a gaggle of gays to say Gaga is not worth it? You *know* there’s a problem.” The Coachella Valley has long been a favorite destination for Canadian snowbirds, who pump millions of

[See **Snowbirds**, A6]

Social Security service upended by cuts

BY JENNY JARVIE AND NATHAN SOLIS

When Veronica Sanchez called a Social Security hotline Thursday, she waited two hours before her call was abruptly disconnected. On Friday, she was on hold for six hours and still did not get through to anyone.

“I’m gonna have to take time out of my work to stand in line and hopefully get this resolved,” the 52-year-old medical practice manager in Canoga Park said Monday. For Sanchez, the stakes are high: If she does not obtain a medical letter from the agency by April 15, her parents, who are on a fixed income, risk losing about \$2,500 a month in medical

care. They would no longer receive insulin medication for their diabetes, she said, and could lose their daily visit from a nurse. But even if Sanchez shows up in person, she is not likely to speak to an agent. Field offices are no longer accepting walk-in appointments. “The system, it’s broken down,” Sanchez said.

Elderly and disabled people — and those who care for them — are encountering a knot of bureaucratic hurdles and service disruptions after the Trump administration imposed a sweeping overhaul of the Social Security Administration system. No field offices in California have closed. But there is rising frustration across

[See **Social Security**, A7]

Another Trump legal victory: The Supreme Court allows the mass firing of new federal workers. **NATION, A5**

A mystery resurfaces off coast: Rising gray whale deaths

Scientists are seeing a repeat six years after a die-off near the North American Pacific shore

BY SUSANNE RUST

Gray whales are dying in large numbers, again. At least 70 whales have perished since the start of the year in the shallow, protected lagoons of Mexico’s Baja California peninsula where the animals have congregated for eons to calf, nurse and breed, said Steven Swartz, a marine scientist who has studied gray whales since 1977. And only five mother-calf pairs were identified in Laguna San Ignacio, where most of the wintering whales tend to congregate, Swartz said. That’s the lowest number of mother-calf pairs ever observed in the lagoon, according to annual reports from Gray Whale Research in Mexico, an international team of researchers — co-founded by Swartz — that

has been observing gray whales in Laguna San Ignacio since the late 1970s. The whales are now headed north. In just the last two weeks, three gray whales have died in San Francisco Bay, one of which was described by veterinarians and pathologists at the Marine Mammal Center in Sausalito as skinny and malnourished. Evaluations on the two other deaths are still being conducted. Alisa Schulman-Janiger, who has led the Los Angeles chapter of the American Cetacean Society’s gray whale census at Rancho Palos Verdes since 1979, said the number of whales she and her volunteers have observed migrating north this spring and swimming south this past winter is the lowest on record. “We didn’t see a single

[See **Whales**, A9]



CAROLYN COLE LOS ANGELES TIMES

A GRAY WHALE pushes her calf to the surface in Laguna San Ignacio, Mexico, in 2021. There have been few mother-calf pairs in the lagoon this year.

Retaliation foreshadows challenges of trade war

Canada and China plan to impose tariffs of their own as world grapples with fallout.

BY FAITH E. PINHO AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Canada will begin imposing 25% tariffs on select U.S. car imports Wednesday, ratcheting up tensions between Washington and Ottawa as the rest of the world grapples with President Trump’s ongoing assault on the global economic order. Canada’s move came hours after Beijing vowed that China would “fight to the end” over the Trump administration’s tariff policy, which it characterized as an attempt to “blackmail” the world. As of Wednesday, all products imported from

China to the United States would face a duty of 104%. The news led to yet another day of market turmoil, with the Dow Jones industrial average, Standard & Poor’s 500 and Nasdaq all beginning the day with promising rallies that disappeared by the closing bell. The steps from two of America’s largest trading partners — one friend, one foe — exemplified the challenges ahead for the Trump administration, which said that its sweeping global tariffs policy on nearly every country on Earth would remain in place. Only direct negotiations with trading partners, on an individual basis, could potentially result in new trade agreements that would lift or ease some restrictions, officials said. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney said Tuesday

[See **Trade**, A6]

Tariffs put L.A. toy and apparel makers in a bind

Many of their goods are produced abroad and ‘cannot be made here,’ one exec says.

BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO

Isaac Larian thought Donald Trump was good for business in his first term when he lowered taxes. So the billionaire entrepreneur figured “common sense” would prevail in his second term, despite the president’s campaign to impose tariffs as a way of resuscitating American manufacturing. It hasn’t worked out that way, stunning the founder and chief executive of MGA Entertainment, the

Chatsworth company that makes its popular Bratz and L.O.L. Surprise dolls and other toys mostly in Asia. A little more than half of MGA’s products are made in China, which on Tuesday vowed to take countermeasures against the United States after Trump threatened an additional 50% tariff on Chinese imports. “Look, I’m not against Trump,” he said. “I think he really genuinely cares for the U.S.A., but it’s wrong to put these tariffs on toys. A lot of toys cannot be made here. What’s going to happen is the following: Let’s say a toy that was sold for \$10 now will be \$20, right? That means that a lot less people can afford it, which means layoffs, which means a small toy

[See **Companies**, A9]

Feds to look into homeless funds

A new task force will investigate potential fraud and corruption in regional services. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Lakers’ Doncic moved by runner

Star finds inspiration from once-paralyzed countryman who went from skier to marathoner. **SPORTS, B10**

Another hurdle for Hollywood?

Trade war could lead China to ban U.S. movies, which already are struggling in the giant market. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather

Sunny and warm. L.A. Basin: 80/54. **B6**

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